Polity Mains Framework Consolidation

One answer engine for all of GS-II Polity: thirteen theme skeletons, a reform bank and a judgment bank, three model answers and a question bank built from 134 Mains PYQs

What this packet is for

Saturday 14 November 2026, morning, about 3½ hours. Thursday and Friday consolidated facts; this session turns them into answers. No new reading: you decode questions, write skeletons against the clock and repair them against the theme frames here.

Polity is 9–11 of the 20 GS-II questions every year from 2013 to 2026 (100–140 marks). The framework is the same D-W-B-H-G-G-R-J spine for every theme, so one method carries the whole paper.

What is inside

1. How Saturday morning runs
2. Mains PYQ demand audit (and Prelims cross-reference)
3. Answer expression toolkit
4. Thirteen theme skeletons, with a comparison grid
5. Three master model answers
6. Reform bank
7. Judgment bank
8. Selective Article spine for Mains
9. Mains analytical question bank (24)
10. Closed-book drill and scoring rubric

How material is labelled

Memorise word for word the spine, numbers and case-years. Understand and reproduce flexibly skeletons and arguments, to rebuild in your words. Conceptual recall only background.

134
Polity Mains PYQs, 2013–2026, re-sorted into 13 answer themes

50
of them asked since 2022 — the live core

44
begin with ‘Discuss’; 13 ask ‘to what extent / how far’

1 How Saturday morning runs

Time	Block	What you do
0:00–0:20	Toolkit	Read Section 3 aloud once. Run the verb decoder on five questions from Section 9.
0:20–1:30	Skeleton sprint	Ten questions from Section 9 (at least one per hot theme: T1, T2, T3, T7, T9, T10, T12). Seven minutes each: write the D-W-B-H-G-G-R-J skeleton, then check it against the theme frame in Section 4 and mark what you missed.
1:30–1:40	Break	
1:40–2:15	Two timed answers	One 15-marker in 18 minutes and one 10-marker in 11 minutes, chosen from the Section 6 questions. Do not look at the model answers first.
2:15–2:35	Score and compare	Score both with the Section 10 rubric, then read the model answers and note the gap.
2:35–3:20	Repair	Rewrite your two weakest skeletons. Say the reform lines (mechanism, institution, accountability) for the five hottest themes aloud until fluent.
3:20–3:30	Log	Record which themes still fail the 3-minute skeleton test; they go to Phase 2.

Exit check

A three-minute skeleton for every hot theme (T1, T2, T3, T7, T9, T10, T12) · both timed answers within the word limit · rubric score of 6/10 or more on each · every reform line names a mechanism, an institution and an accountability consequence.

2 Mains PYQ demand audit

All 134 Polity questions from the UnlockIAS GS-II file (2013–2026), re-sorted by the theme an answer needs, not by the source's headings. 'Hot' = asked three or more times since 2022, or asked in 2026.

Theme	Qs	Marks	Since 2022	Last	Status	Years
T1 Local government and devolution	11	132	5	**2026**	Hot	2013, 2015, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025, 2026
T2 Federalism, Centre–state relations and asymmetry	16	202	5	**2026**	Hot	2013, 2013, 2013, 2014, 2015, 2016, 2016, 2016, 2018, 2020, 2020, 2023, 2024, 2025, 2025, 2026
T3 Governor and the state legislature	4	55	3	**2026**	Hot	2021, 2022, 2023, 2026
T4 Judiciary: independence and accountability	5	60	3	**2025**	Hot	2017, 2021, 2023, 2025, 2025
T5 Judicial review, PIL and separation of powers	5	68	2	**2026**	Hot	2014, 2019, 2020, 2024, 2026
T6 Parliament, committees and executive accountability	16	195	3	**2024**	Hot	2014, 2014, 2014, 2015, 2017, 2017, 2018, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2020, 2021, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024
T7 Elections, the ECI, the Speaker and anti-defection	12	140	6	**2026**	Hot	2013, 2017, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2022, 2022, 2024, 2025, 2026, 2026
T8 Tribunals, quasi-judicial bodies and regulators	10	115	3	**2025**	Hot	2013, 2014, 2015, 2015, 2016, 2018, 2019, 2023, 2024, 2025
T9 Constitutional and statutory bodies	20	248	5	**2026**	Hot	2013, 2014, 2015, 2016, 2017, 2017, 2018, 2018, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2020, 2021, 2021, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025, 2026
T10 Rights and the expanding Article 21	12	148	6	**2026**	Hot	2013, 2014, 2015, 2015, 2017, 2021, 2022, 2022, 2023, 2023, 2024, 2026
T11 Amending power and constitutional design	5	65	1	**2025**	Steady	2013, 2016, 2016, 2019, 2025
T12 Comparative constitutions	9	110	5	**2026**	Hot	2019, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025, 2026
T13 Parties, pressure groups and civil society	9	110	3	**2026**	Hot	2013, 2015, 2016, 2017, 2019, 2021, 2022, 2025, 2026

What the audit says

Four themes carry nearly half (48%) of the 1,648 marks: **constitutional and statutory bodies** (T9, 248), **federalism** (T2, 202), **Parliament** (T6, 195) and **rights** (T10, 148). The hottest since 2022 are **elections and the Speaker** (6), **rights** (6), **comparisons** (5 of 9 since 2022), **local government** and **federalism** (5 each). Parliament (T6) has gone quiet since 2024 — a classic return candidate.

Prelims cross-reference: this row has no Prelims drill of its own; the Prelims demand for every theme was audited in PC-I (Seq 32, 275 questions) and PC-II (Seq 33, 111 questions).

How questions are worded

Verb	Count
Discuss	44
Explain	16
To what extent / How far	13
Comment	8
Examine	7
Critically examine / evaluate	7
Suggest measures	6
Analyse	5
Compare / contrast	5

Half of all recent questions are 15-markers (250 words); the rest are 10-markers (150 words).

3 Answer expression toolkit

The spine: D-W-B-H-G-G-R-J

Memorise word for word

Step	Plain meaning	Functional phrase	Answer-ready opener
Definition	Say what the thing is, in one line	'It is…'	'X is a constitutionally mandated / statutory … under Art. …'
Why	Why it exists	'It exists because…'	'The framers created it to …' / 'It responds to …'
Basis	Where it sits in law	'It is rooted in…'	'Its basis lies in Art. …, read with … (case, year).'
How	How it works in practice	'It works through…'	'In practice it operates through three channels: …'
Gains	What it has achieved	'It has delivered…'	'Its record is real: … (evidence, data, case).'
Gaps	Where it falls short	'Yet…'	'However, three gaps persist: …'
Reforms	What should change, by whom, with what consequence	'Mechanism → institution → accountability'	'…, enacted by …, so that … must answer to …'
Judgement	Your balanced verdict	'On balance…'	'On balance, X has … ; its future depends on …'

A 10-marker can compress W into D and merge the two G's into one 'assessment' paragraph. A 15-marker uses all eight.

Six lenses to widen any answer

Understand and reproduce flexibly

Lens	Ask yourself
Constitutional	Which Articles and values are engaged?
Institutional	Is the design, capacity or independence the issue?
Democratic	Who is represented, who participates, who answers?
Federal	Does it shift power between Union and states?
Judicial	Which cases fixed or changed the position?
Reform / comparative	Which committee, report or country offers a fix?

Pick two or three lenses per answer; never all six.

Demand-verb decoder

Understand and reproduce flexibly

Verb	What it wants	Shape
Discuss	Both sides, broadly	Points for and against, then a verdict
Examine	Probe the parts with evidence	Factor by factor, each with proof
Critically examine / evaluate	Both sides, weighted	Merits, demerits, explicit verdict
Comment	A justified opinion	Position first, then reasons
Analyse	Break into causes or components	Cause → effect clusters
Explain / Elucidate	Make it clear with examples	Concept → mechanism → example
To what extent / How far	Degree, not yes or no	'Largely, but…' verdict up front
Suggest measures	Specific reforms	Mechanism–institution–accountability lines
Compare / contrast	Same axes for both	A table or paired points

Five ways to open

Understand and reproduce flexibly

Type	Example
Definition	'The Governor is the constitutional head of the state, appointed by the President under Art. 155.'
Constitutional anchor	'Art. 75(3) makes the Council of Ministers collectively responsible to the Lok Sabha.'
Data	'Only 16% of bills in the 17th Lok Sabha went to committees (PRS).'
Case	'In Bommai (1994) the SC made Art. 356 justiciable.'

Three ways to close

Understand and reproduce flexibly

Type	Example
Constitutional value	'…so that the Governor remains a sentinel of the Constitution, not a rival to the elected government.'
Committee or report	'As the Punchhi Commission urged, a time limit for assent would end the stalemate.'
Forward-looking	'Trust between Union and states, not new powers, is the next stage of cooperative federalism.'

Type	Example
Current event	'The Nov 2025 Presidential Reference ruled out court-set timelines for assent.'

Word and time budgets

Memorise word for word

	10 marks · 150 words · 7 min	15 marks · 250 words · 11 min
Intro	20 words	30 words
Body	3–4 points × 25 words	2 sub-heads × 3 points
Reform line	1 line	2–3 lines
Conclusion	20 words	20–30 words

Diagrams that earn marks in Polity: a flowchart for a procedure (Art. 200 options, removal of judges); a three-column table for a comparison; a hub-and-spoke for federal institutions; a timeline for a case ladder (Golaknath → Kesavananda → Minerva).

4 Theme skeletons

Each frame is a full 15-mark skeleton. The plain-language line comes first; the rows are the answer.

Understand and reproduce flexibly

T1 · Local government and devolution

11 Mains Qs · 132 marks · last 2026

> **Plain:** The Constitution created a third tier of government in 1992, but states decide how much power, money and staff it actually gets.

Definition	Panchayats and municipalities are constitutionally mandated institutions of self-government (Parts IX and IX-A, 73rd and 74th Amendments, 1992).
Why	They bring decisions close to the people affected (subsidiarity), widen representation (one-third women, SC/ST seats) and improve service delivery.
Basis	Art. 40 (DPSP); Arts. 243–243O and 243P–243ZG; Eleventh (29) and Twelfth (18) Schedules; SEC (243K/243ZA); SFC (243I/243Y); DPC and MPC (243ZD–ZE); PESA 1996.
How	Three tiers, five-year terms, elections by the SEC within six months of dissolution, devolution of functions by state law, grants on SFC advice.
Gains	Several lakh elected representatives with a large share of women (MoPR); political entry for SC/ST and women; gram sabha as direct democracy; 15th FC grants tied to audited accounts.
Gaps	The 3Fs gap: functions listed but not transferred, thin own revenue, staff controlled by state departments. Proxy representation by male relatives. Parastatals bypass city councils. Weak mayors. SFCs delayed. Elections postponed until the SC intervened.
Reforms	→ **Statutory activity mapping that assigns each Eleventh/Twelfth Schedule subject to a tier with matching funds and staff** · State legislature, with MoPR's devolution index as the benchmark · *The SFC and the CAG report devolution gaps to the assembly each year* → **Grants conditional on audited accounts and a property-tax floor** · Finance Commission and state governments · *Unaudited bodies lose grants, so councils must publish accounts* → **Directly elected mayors with a fixed five-year term and control over city agencies** · State municipal law · *Mayors answer to voters and councils, not to state-appointed commissioners*
Judgement	**The architecture of 1992 is in place; what is missing is 'functionality' — real power, money and staff at the third tier.**

Evidence pegs: 2nd ARC 6th Report (Local Governance, 2007) · Balwant Rai Mehta 1957, Ashok Mehta 1977, L.M. Singhvi 1986 · Vikas Kishanrao Gawali 2021 (triple test for OBC seats) · Suresh Mahajan 2022 (no postponing local polls) · RBI Report on Municipal Finances 2024

Asked as: 2026 women's reservation from local bodies to Parliament · 2025 decisions far from information · 2024 merging rural and urban bodies · 2023 states reluctant to empower ULBs · 2022 decentralisation · 2020 'functionality'

T2 · Federalism, Centre–state relations and asymmetry

16 Mains Qs · 202 marks · last 2026

> **Plain:** India is a union that holds diverse units together under a strong Centre, with special arrangements for some regions.

Definition	A 'Union of States' (Art. 1): an indestructible Union of destructible states, federal in form with a unitary bias, often called quasi-federal (K.C. Wheare) or cooperative (Granville Austin).
Why	To keep a diverse country united while letting regions govern themselves; asymmetry accommodates distinct identities (Fifth/Sixth Schedules, Art. 371).
Basis	Seventh Schedule; Arts. 245–263 (legislative, administrative), 268–293 and 280 (financial), 279A (GST Council), 356, 365; federalism is a basic feature (Bommai 1994).
How	Distribution of Lists; override clauses (249–254); Finance Commission transfers; GST Council pooling; Inter-State and Zonal Councils; NITI Governing Council.
Gains	Linguistic reorganisation stabilised the Union; GST pooled fiscal sovereignty; 14th and 15th FC raised the states' share of the divisible pool to 42% and 41%; Art. 356 use fell sharply after Bommai.
Gaps	Centralising laws in crises (Epidemic Diseases Act, DM Act — Mains 2020); cesses and surcharges outside the divisible pool; Governors in conflict with elected governments; central agencies and consent withdrawals; delimitation and the North–South representation question; GST compensation ended in 2022.
Reforms	→ **Bring cesses and surcharges beyond a cap into the divisible pool** · Parliament, by amending Arts. 270–271, with the Finance Commission monitoring · *The FC reports the cap's breach to Parliament, which must justify it* → **A standing Inter-State Council with its own secretariat and fixed meeting cycle** · President's order under Art. 263, as Punchhi recommended · *An annual report on Centre–state disputes laid before Parliament* → **Appoint Governors after consulting the Chief Minister, with fixed tenure** · Constitutional amendment of Arts. 155–156 (Sarkaria, Punchhi) · *Removal only for stated cause, reviewable by courts*
Judgement	**Indian federalism has proved flexible, not fragile; its future depends on institutional trust between the Centre and the states, not just on transfers.**

Evidence pegs: Rajamannar 1969 · Sarkaria 1988 · Punchhi 2010 · State of WB v Union 1962 · Bommai 1994 · Mohit Minerals 2022 · GNCTD 2018, 2023 · In re Art. 370 (2023) · 131st Amendment Bill defeat (Apr 2026)

Asked as: 2026 accommodation of diversity and dispute resolution · 2025 fiscal federalism · 2024 recent changes and trust-building · 2023 decline of Art. 356 · 2020 cooperation, competition, confrontation

T3 · Governor and the state legislature

4 Mains Qs · 55 marks · last 2026

> **Plain:** The Governor is the state's constitutional head who normally acts on the elected government's advice, but holds a few discretionary powers that have become flashpoints.

Definition	A centrally appointed constitutional head of the state (Art. 153) who acts on the advice of the Council of Ministers except where the Constitution allows discretion (Art. 163).
Why	A link between the Union and the state, and a guardian of constitutional processes when the elected machinery fails.
Basis	Arts. 153–167, 163, 174 (summoning), 200–201 (assent), 213 (ordinances), 356 (report); Shamsher Singh 1974, Nabam Rebia 2016, B.P. Singhal 2010.
How	Assent options under Art. 200: assent, withhold, return, reserve; discretion in appointing a CM in a hung House and in reporting under Art. 356.
Gains	Continuity during political crises; reservation protects the High Court and Union interests; the 2025 opinion said Governors cannot sit on Bills indefinitely.
Gaps	Bills held for months or years; partisan use of discretion; removal at pleasure; no time limit in Art. 200; the April 2025 timelines and 'deemed assent' were overturned by the 20 November 2025 opinion.
Reforms	→ **Amend Art. 200 to set a time limit for decisions on Bills** · Parliament, by constitutional amendment (Punchhi suggested six months for reserved Bills) · *Delay beyond the limit becomes a reviewable breach of a constitutional duty* → **A binding code of conduct for Governors on discretion and appointments** · Inter-State Council adopts it; President issues it · *Departures must be recorded with reasons, which the Assembly can debate* → **Speaker to decide disqualification petitions within three months** · Tenth Schedule amendment, codifying Padi Kaushik Reddy (2025) · *Missed deadlines open the decision to judicial review*
Judgement	**The Governor is meant to be a constitutional sentinel, not a parallel government; timelines and reasons would restore that design.**

Evidence pegs: Shamsher Singh 1974 · Rameshwar Prasad 2006 · B.P. Singhal 2010 · Nabam Rebia 2016 · Krishna Kumar Singh 2017 · State of TN v Governor (Apr 2025) · Presidential Reference opinion (20 Nov 2025) · Sarkaria, Punchhi

Asked as: 2026 Governor's assent and aid and advice · 2023 presiding officers · 2022 Governor's ordinances · 2021 Legislative Councils

T4 · Judiciary: independence and accountability

5 Mains Qs · 60 marks · last 2025

> **Plain:** Judges must be free from pressure to decide fairly, but they must also answer for misconduct; India has protected the first far better than the second.

Definition	Independence is insulation of judges' appointment, tenure, pay and removal from the other branches; accountability is answerability for conduct and performance.
Why	Courts enforce limits on power, so they must be free; public trust requires that they also be answerable.
Basis	Arts. 50, 124, 217, 121 and 211 (no discussion of judges' conduct), 129/215 (contempt); Judges (Inquiry) Act 1968; Three Judges Cases; NJAC case 2015; in-house procedure (1999).
How	Collegium recommendations; fixed retirement ages; salaries charged on the Consolidated Fund; removal only by special-majority address of both Houses.
Gains	Independence secured against the executive; collegium resolutions published since 2017; the 2025–26 Varma inquiry showed the Judges (Inquiry) Act can work to the point of findings.
Gaps	Opaque collegium; Memorandum of Procedure not finalised; vacancies and delays; low diversity; post-retirement posts; no judge ever removed — Justice Varma resigned in April 2026 before the committee found the charges proved.
Reforms	→ **Finalise the Memorandum of Procedure with timelines and a secretariat** · Supreme Court collegium with the Union Law Ministry · *Reasons and timelines are published, so delays can be traced* → **Amend the Judges (Inquiry) Act so inquiries continue after resignation and findings carry consequences** · Parliament · *Resignation can no longer erase the record of misconduct* → **A cooling-off period before post-retirement appointments** · Parliament by law, or a full-court resolution · *Removes the incentive to please the executive before retirement*
Judgement	**Independence and accountability are not rivals; constitutional morality requires both, and the gap today is on accountability.**

Evidence pegs: S.P. Gupta 1981 · SCAORA 1993 · In re 1998 · C. Ravichandran Iyer 1995 · SCAORA (NJAC) 2015 · Manoj Narula 2014 (constitutional morality) · NCRWC 2002 (National Judicial Commission) · Justice Varma inquiry (2025–26)

Asked as: 2025 collegium vs USA · 2025 constitutional morality and accountability · 2023 judicial independence and democracy · 2021 women in higher judiciary · 2017 NJAC judgment

T5 · Judicial review, PIL and separation of powers

5 Mains Qs · 68 marks · last 2026

> **Plain:** Courts test laws and actions against the Constitution; through PIL they have also issued guidelines when the legislature was silent.

Definition	Judicial review is the power to invalidate unconstitutional laws and actions; judicial legislation is court-made guidelines filling a legislative vacuum.
Why	It enforces constitutional limits and protects rights of those who cannot approach courts themselves.
Basis	Arts. 13, 32, 136, 141, 142, 226; India follows checks and balances, not strict separation (Ram Jawaya Kapur 1955); separation of powers is a basic feature (Raj Narain 1975).
How	Relaxed locus standi and epistolary jurisdiction; guidelines (Vishaka 1997, D.K. Basu 1997, Prakash Singh 2006, Common Cause 2018); continuing mandamus.
Gains	Rights expansion; environmental constitutionalism (M.C. Mehta cases — Mains 2022); prison, police and custodial reforms.
Gaps	Overreach and weak compliance; PIL misuse; docket pressure; Art. 142 stretched (the April 2025 'deemed assent' was rejected by the November 2025 reference).
Reforms	→ **Rules for screening PILs, with costs for frivolous petitions** · Supreme Court rules under Art. 145 · *Admission becomes reasoned and reviewable* → **Dialogic remedies: courts set principles and timelines, legislatures enact** · Parliament and state legislatures, as after Vishaka (POSH Act 2013) · *Compliance hearings track whether the legislature acted* → **A permanent constitutional division of the Supreme Court** · Parliament and the SC (Law Commission 229th Report, 2009) · *Constitutional questions decided on time, by benches of known strength*
Judgement	**Judicial activism is legitimate when it fills a rights gap and recedes when institutions act; restraint and activism are both duties.**

Evidence pegs: Ram Jawaya Kapur 1955 · Kesavananda 1973 · S.P. Gupta 1981 · Vishaka 1997 · Vineet Narain 1997 · Prakash Singh 2006 · Common Cause 2018 · Presidential Reference 2025

Asked as: 2026 judicial legislation and euthanasia · 2024 growth of PIL · 2020 judicial legislation vs separation of powers · 2019 checks and balances · 2014 judicial activism

T6 · Parliament, committees and executive accountability

16 Mains Qs · 195 marks · last 2024

> **Plain:** Parliament's job is to make the executive answer every day, not just at elections; its tools exist, but they are used less.

Definition	Parliamentary accountability is the continuous answerability of the Council of Ministers to the Lok Sabha (Art. 75(3)).
Why	It turns a five-yearly mandate into daily control over law, money and policy.
Basis	Arts. 75, 79–122, 105 (privileges), 108 (joint sitting), 110 (Money Bill); Rules of Procedure; financial committees and DRSCs.
How	Question Hour, Zero Hour, motions; PAC, Estimates and COPU; 24 DRSCs; budget scrutiny; Rajya Sabha as revising chamber.
Gains	PAC reports on major audits; DRSC scrutiny of bills; the Rajya Sabha's revising role (Mains 2020).
Gaps	Fewer sittings (the 17th Lok Sabha held 274); falling referral of bills to committees (PRS: 60% in the 14th, 71% in the 15th, 27% in the 16th, 16% in the 17th Lok Sabha); Money Bill route to bypass the Rajya Sabha; the Deputy Speaker's post left vacant through the 17th Lok Sabha; whip and anti-defection curb MPs (Mains 2013, 2019).
Reforms	→ **A minimum number of sitting days (NCRWC suggested 120 for the Lok Sabha, 100 for the Rajya Sabha)** · Parliament, by law or its Rules · *Shortfalls are reported to the House and the public each year* → **Default referral of bills to committees unless the Speaker records reasons** · Rules of Procedure of each House · *Bypassing scrutiny requires a recorded, public justification* → **Limit whips to confidence and Money Bills** · Tenth Schedule amendment (Law Commission 170th Report, 1999; Dinesh Goswami 1990) · *MPs vote on other bills by conscience and answer to their voters*
Judgement	**Parliament has not lost its powers; it has lost the habit of using them.**

Evidence pegs: PRS Legislative Research data · NCRWC 2002 · Law Commission 170th Report 1999 · Kihoto 1992 · Rojer Mathew 2019 · Sita Soren 2024 (privilege)

Asked as: 2024 cabinet system and parliamentary supremacy · 2023 committee system · 2022 VP as RS Chairman · 2021 executive accountability, DRSCs · 2020 Rajya Sabha · 2019 decline of the MP

T7 · Elections, the ECI, the Speaker and anti-defection

12 Mains Qs · 140 marks · last 2026

> **Plain:** Free elections need an umpire the government cannot capture, rules that keep money and crime out, and a fair referee for defections.

Definition	The electoral system is the constitutional and statutory machinery (Arts. 324–329, RPA 1950 and 1951, Tenth Schedule) that converts votes into mandates and keeps them stable.
Why	Free and fair elections are part of the basic structure (Raj Narain 1975); without them every other institution loses legitimacy.
Basis	Art. 324 (ECI), 326 (adult suffrage), 329 (bar on courts mid-election); RPA 1950 (rolls), 1951 (conduct, disqualification); CEC Act 2023; Tenth Schedule; MCC (not statutory).
How	ECI superintendence and the MCC; roll revision under RPA 1950; election petitions in High Courts; Speaker decides defections.
Gains	Peaceful transfers of power; EVMs with VVPAT; NOTA; electoral bonds struck down (2024) for transparency.
Gaps	Money power; criminalisation (ADR found 46% of Lok Sabha MPs elected in 2024 declared criminal cases); executive-heavy ECI panel; partisan Speakers and delays (Telangana 2025); defections via resignations; disputes over roll revision.
Reforms	→ **Disqualification petitions decided by an independent tribunal, or by the President or Governor on the ECI's binding advice** · Constitutional amendment of the Tenth Schedule (Dinesh Goswami 1990; Meghachandra 2020; Padi Kaushik Reddy 2025) · *Decisions become time-bound, reasoned and free of party interest* → **A CEC selection panel that includes the CJI** · Parliament, amending the 2023 Act (Tarkunde 1975; Law Commission 255th Report 2015) · *Appointments gain bipartisan legitimacy* → **Disqualification on framing of charges for serious offences, with safeguards** · Parliament, amending the RPA (Law Commission 244th Report 2014) · *Parties face a legal cost for fielding such candidates*
Judgement	**India runs elections with rare competence; the reform frontier is the independence of the referees — the ECI and the Speaker.**

Evidence pegs: Raj Narain 1975 · Jyoti Basu 1982 / Kuldip Nayar 2006 (right to vote statutory) · PUCL 2003 (voting as expression) · Lal Babu Hussein 1995 · Kihoto 1992 · Lily Thomas 2013 · Anoop Baranwal 2023 · ADR 2024 · Kovind Committee 2024 (ONOE; 129th Bill with the JPC)

Asked as: 2026 right to vote and roll revision · 2026 Speaker's neutrality · 2025 corrupt practices · 2024 ONOE · 2022 MCC · 2022 election disputes · 2020 'once a Speaker, always a Speaker'

T8 · Tribunals, quasi-judicial bodies and regulators

10 Mains Qs · 115 marks · last 2025

> **Plain:** Specialised bodies decide disputes faster than courts, but only if the government does not control who sits on them.

Definition	Tribunals are specialised adjudicatory bodies under Arts. 323A/323B or statutes; quasi-judicial bodies decide disputes like courts without being courts.
Why	Expertise, speed and lower cost, and relief for the regular courts.
Basis	Arts. 323A, 323B (42nd Amendment), 227; L. Chandra Kumar 1997 (High Court review); Madras Bar Association cases 2010, 2014, 2020, 2021, 2025.
How	Statutory tribunals (CAT, NGT, NCLT, ITAT); regulators (CCI, SEBI, TRAI); Lok Adalats and arbitration as alternative dispute resolution (Mains 2024).
Gains	Specialised adjudication in tax, company, environment and service law; NGT's environmental jurisprudence.
Gaps	Executive control over selection, tenure and pay; vacancies; appeals straight to the SC; on 19 November 2025 the SC struck down the 2021 Act's four-year tenure and 50-year age bar as a re-enactment of what it had already invalidated.
Reforms	→ **A National Tribunals Commission to run appointments, service conditions and administration** · Parliament (SC direction of Nov 2025; a 2026 Bill passed the Lok Sabha in August 2026) · *Tribunals report to an independent body, reviewable by courts, not to the parent ministry* → **Tenure and age rules fixed in line with the Madras Bar judgments** · Parliament · *Members cannot be pressured through reappointment* → **Appeals to High Court division benches rather than straight to the SC** · Parliament, amending parent statutes · *Restores the High Courts' supervisory role (L. Chandra Kumar)*
Judgement	**Tribunals are justified only if they are as independent as the courts they replace.**

Evidence pegs: R.K. Jain 1993 · L. Chandra Kumar 1997 · Madras Bar Association 2010, 2014, 2020, 2021, 19 Nov 2025 · Rojer Mathew 2019

Asked as: 2025 tribunal rationalisation · 2024 Lok Adalats vs arbitration · 2023 CCI · 2019 CAT · 2018 tribunals vs courts · 2016 quasi-judicial bodies · 2015 regulators' independence

T9 · Constitutional and statutory bodies

20 Mains Qs · 248 marks · last 2026

> **Plain:** Watchdogs like the CAG, the Finance Commission and the rights commissions are only as strong as their independence and their power to make governments act.

Definition	Constitutional bodies (CAG, FC, UPSC, NCSC, NCST, NCBC) draw powers from the Constitution; statutory bodies (NHRC, CIC, CVC, Lokpal) from Acts of Parliament.
Why	They supply expert, continuous accountability that elected bodies cannot.
Basis	Arts. 148–151, 280, 315–323, 338–338B; PHRA 1993, RTI 2005, CVC 2003, Lokpal 2013; 102nd and 105th Amendments (NCBC; states' SEBC lists).
How	Audit (CAG), fiscal transfers (FC), recruitment (UPSC), rights monitoring and inquiry (NHRC, NCSC/NCST), disclosure (CIC), vigilance (CVC, Lokpal).
Gains	CAG's performance audits beyond legality (Mains 2024: propriety); FC-driven devolution; RTI as a citizen's right; NCBC's constitutional status (2018).
Gaps	Recommendatory powers; selection panels dominated by the executive; the 2019 RTI amendment and the 2023 DPDP change; vacancies; CAG reports wait for PAC discussion.
Reforms	→ **Findings of NHRC, NCSC and NCST binding unless rejected with written reasons** · Parliament, amending the PHRA and adding to Arts. 338–338A · *Governments must justify non-compliance before the legislature* → **Commissioners' tenure and pay fixed in the statute** · Parliament, amending the RTI Act · *The executive can no longer vary terms to signal displeasure* → **A permanent Finance Commission secretariat** · Parliament, amending the FC Act 1951 · *Continuity and data between commissions, reported to Parliament*
Judgement	**Constitutional status gives these bodies dignity; independence and enforceable follow-up give them effect.**

Evidence pegs: Vineet Narain 1997 · Jaishri Patil 2021 and the 105th Amendment · RTI Amendment 2019 · DPDP 2023 · Lokpal 2019 · steps to constitutionalise a body: an Art. 368 amendment inserting it (as the 102nd did for the NCBC)

Asked as: 2026 NCSC/NCST enforcement · 2025 Attorney General · 2024 CAG propriety · 2022 NCBC · 2021 NHRC limits · 2020 RTI amendment · 2020 constitutionalising the NCW

T10 · Rights and the expanding Article 21

12 Mains Qs · 148 marks · last 2026

> **Plain:** The Supreme Court has read 'life and personal liberty' to cover dignity, privacy, environment and identity, making the Constitution a living document.

Definition	The 'living instrument' approach reads Fundamental Rights expansively and as linked, not as separate codes (Cooper 1970, Maneka 1978).
Why	Rights must grow with society; a static text would fail new problems such as data, climate and gender identity.
Basis	Arts. 14, 15(3), 19, 21, 21A, 32; DPSP as interpretive guides; Puttaswamy 2017 (privacy); NALSA 2014 (gender identity).
How	Interpretation by courts; follow-up statutes (POSH 2013, Transgender Persons Act 2019, DPDP 2023).
Gains	Dignity, livelihood, environment, privacy, decriminalisation (Navtej), living wills, climate (Ranjitsinh 2024); gender justice through Vishaka, Shayara Bano 2017, Joseph Shine 2018, Babita Puniya 2020.
Gaps	Rights declared but weakly enforced; the 2026 amendment to the Transgender Act requires medical scrutiny, in tension with NALSA's self-identification and Puttaswamy's autonomy (Mains 2026); hate speech vs free speech balance.
Reforms	→ **Rights-impact assessment for new bills** · Parliament, through its Rules and committees · *Bills that dilute recognised rights must say so openly* → **Independent oversight of the Data Protection Board** · Parliament, amending the DPDP Act · *Privacy is protected from the state as well as from companies*
Judgement	**Article 21 has become the Constitution's engine of growth; its credibility now depends on enforcement, not new declarations.**

Evidence pegs: Gopalan 1950 · Cooper 1970 · Maneka 1978 · Olga Tellis 1985 · Vishaka 1997 · NALSA 2014 · Shreya Singhal 2015 · Puttaswamy 2017 · Navtej 2018 · Common Cause 2018 · Babita Puniya 2020 · Ranjitsinh 2024

Asked as: 2026 transgender amendment and privacy · 2024 privacy and DNA tests · 2023 living instrument · 2023 gender justice · 2022 movement and residence · 2021 constitutional morality

T11 · Amending power and constitutional design

5 Mains Qs · 65 marks · last 2025

> **Plain:** Parliament can change the Constitution, but only by a hard procedure and never so as to destroy its basic structure.

Definition	The amending power (Art. 368) is a constituent power exercised by Parliament under procedural and substantive limits.
Why	To let the Constitution adapt without letting a passing majority remake it.
Basis	Art. 368; 24th, 42nd, 44th Amendments; Kesavananda 1973, Raj Narain 1975, Minerva 1980, Waman Rao 1981, Coelho 2007, NJAC 2015.
How	Procedural limits: special majority in each House separately, state ratification for federal provisions, no joint sitting. Substantive limits: basic structure and judicial review of amendments.
Gains	106 amendments without a rupture; basic structure checked the Emergency-era 39th and 42nd; the 131st Bill's defeat (April 2026) shows the procedural check working.
Gaps	The basic structure is judge-defined and open-ended; amendments passed with little debate; state ratification rarely contested.
Reforms	→ **Pre-legislative consultation and committee scrutiny for every amendment bill** · Parliament, through its Rules (and the 2014 pre-legislative consultation policy) · *Major changes are debated before votes are counted*
Judgement	**The amending power is wide but not unlimited; the basic structure is the Constitution's identity, and the special majority its everyday guard.**

Evidence pegs: Shankari Prasad 1951 · Golaknath 1967 · Kesavananda 1973 · Minerva 1980 · Coelho 2007 · NJAC 2015 · Balram Singh 2024

Asked as: 2025 procedural and substantive limits · 2019 can Parliament destroy the basic structure · 2016 Coelho · 2016 Preamble's adjectives · 2016 GoI Act 1935 as federal

T12 · Comparative constitutions

9 Mains Qs · 110 marks · last 2026

> **Plain:** UPSC asks how India's choices differ from the US, UK and France — and why.

Definition	Comparative analysis explains Indian design by contrast: what India borrowed, adapted or rejected.
Why	It shows that Indian solutions are deliberate, not accidental.
Basis	Borrowings (UK, USA, Ireland, Canada, Australia, Weimar, USSR, France, South Africa, Japan).
How	Compare on a fixed set of axes: executive, separation of powers, judicial review, amendment, federalism, secularism, equality, pardon, judicial appointments.
Gains	Answers that compare on axes score better than lists of differences.
Gaps	Answers that list differences without fixed axes, and without saying why India chose differently, lose marks.
Reforms	Use the comparison grid below.
Judgement	**India blends Westminster government with American-style judicial review, adapted to a diverse, unequal society.**

Evidence pegs: See the comparison grid in Section 4.

Asked as: 2026 separation of powers India vs USA · 2025 pardon India vs USA · 2024 secularism India vs USA · 2023 parliamentary sovereignty UK vs India · 2022 electing Presidents of India and France · 2021 equality USA vs India · 2020 judiciary India vs UK · 2019 France and Indian secularism

Comparison grid

Memorise word for word

Axis	India	USA	UK	France
Executive	PM and Cabinet answerable to the Lok Sabha; President nominal	President directly elected, fixed term, not answerable to Congress	PM and Cabinet in Parliament; monarch nominal	President directly elected; PM answerable to the Assembly (semi-presidential)
Separation of powers	Checks and balances; executive drawn from legislature	Strict separation with checks (veto, Senate consent)	Fusion; parliamentary sovereignty	Separation with strong presidency
Judicial review	Strong; basic structure limits even amendments	Strong (Marbury v Madison 1803)	Limited; courts cannot strike Acts (declaration of incompatibility, 1998 Act)	Constitutional Council reviews laws
Amendment	Art. 368: flexible-rigid mix	Very rigid: Congress 2/3 + 3/4 of states	Ordinary law (no written constitution)	Parliament in Congress (3/5) or referendum
Federalism	Union of States; strong Centre; asymmetry	Coming-together federation; strong states	Unitary with devolution	Unitary
Secularism	Principled distance; state may reform religion (Art. 25(2))	Wall of separation (First Amendment)	Established church	Laïcité: strict separation
Pardon	President on advice; after conviction; limited review	President personal; pre-emptive possible	Royal prerogative on ministerial advice	President, individual pardons only
Judicial appointments	Collegium (CJI + 4)	President nominates, Senate confirms	Judicial Appointments Commission (2005)	Executive with judicial council

T13 · Parties, pressure groups and civil society

9 Mains Qs · 110 marks · last 2026

> **Plain:** Democracy works through organised interests as well as elections; the question is whether they widen voice or concentrate influence.

Definition	Pressure groups seek to influence policy without contesting power; parties seek to form government; civil society is the organised space between state and market.
Why	They carry excluded interests into policy and hold governments to account between elections.
Basis	Art. 19(1)(a), (b), (c); RPA s. 29A; Symbols Order 1968; FCRA 2010 (2020 amendment).
How	Lobbying, protest, litigation, expert input; Almond and Powell's four types.
Gains	Farmers' mobilisation led to repeal of the farm laws (Nov 2021); environmental movements (Chipko, Narmada) shaped law; business associations shape economic policy.
Gaps	No lobbying disclosure law; corporate money and politics (electoral bonds struck down 2024); weak internal party democracy; CIC's 2013 order making national parties public authorities under RTI never complied with; FCRA tightening (2020).
Reforms	→ **A lobbying disclosure register** · Parliament, by law · *Who met whom on what becomes public* → **Internal party democracy and accounts audited and published** · ECI, under amended RPA s. 29A · *Parties lose recognition benefits if they do not comply*
Judgement	**Organised interests deepen democracy when they are transparent; they threaten it when influence is hidden.**

Evidence pegs: Almond & Powell · Rajni Kothari (Congress system) · CIC order 2013 · ADR v Union of India 2024 · FCRA Amendment 2020

Asked as: 2026 pressure groups and corporate power · 2025 environmental pressure groups · 2022 national vs regional parties · 2021 business associations · 2019 farmers' organisations

5 Master model answers

Read only after you have written your own timed answer. Understand and reproduce flexibly

A1 · 2026 GS-II Q11 · 15 marks · 250 words

Discuss the position of the Governor in the federal polity of India. What is the nature of his power while giving assent to a bill passed by the State Legislature? Is he bound by the aid and advice of his Council of Ministers in all his functions?

The Governor, appointed by the President under Art. 155, is the constitutional head of a state — in Sarkaria's words, a vital link between Union and state.

Position in the federal polity. (i) Nominal head: executive power is exercised on the Council of Ministers' advice (Art. 163; Shamsher Singh, 1974). (ii) Union link: reports under Art. 356 and reservation of Bills for the President. (iii) Serves at pleasure, but cannot be removed arbitrarily (B.P. Singhal, 2010).

Nature of the assent power (Art. 200). The Governor may assent, withhold assent, return a non-Money Bill once (and must then assent if it is re-passed), or reserve it — mandatorily if it derogates from the High Court's powers. The text sets no deadline. The 20 November 2025 advisory opinion overturned the April 2025 timelines: courts cannot impose deadlines or deem assent, though a Governor cannot sit on a Bill indefinitely.

Is he always bound by advice? No. Discretion exists where the Constitution says so (Sixth Schedule para 9, Art. 371 special responsibilities, Art. 356 reports) and in situations such as choosing a Chief Minister in a hung House, or sanctioning prosecution of a minister where bias is apparent (M.P. Special Police Establishment, 2004). But Nabam Rebia (2016) confined discretion narrowly; summoning the House follows advice.

Way forward: a constitutional time limit for assent (Punchhi) and a code of conduct for discretion.

Read together, the text and the cases make the Governor a sentinel of the Constitution, not a parallel government.

247 words · spine used: D (opening) → B/H → Gains/Gaps → Reforms → Judgement

A2 · 2023 GS-II Q13 · 15 marks · 250 words

Account for the legal and political factors responsible for the reduced frequency of using Article 356 by the Union Governments since mid-1990s.

Article 356 has been invoked over a hundred times since 1950, often to dismiss opposition governments. Since the mid-1990s its use has become rare and short — closer to the 'dead letter' Ambedkar hoped it would be.

Legal factors. (i) S.R. Bommai (1994) made the proclamation justiciable, demanded relevant material, made the floor test the proper check of majority, and held that the Assembly may only be suspended until Parliament approves — so courts can restore it. (ii) Later rulings enforced this: Rameshwar Prasad (2006) struck the Bihar dissolution; the Uttarakhand (2016) and Arunachal (Nabam Rebia, 2016) episodes ended with governments restored. (iii) The 44th Amendment limits extension beyond a year to a national emergency plus an ECI certificate. (iv) Sarkaria's 'last resort' guidelines became the benchmark courts apply.

Political factors. (i) Coalition governments from 1989 depended on regional parties that opposed misuse. (ii) Approval needs both Houses, and ruling coalitions often lacked a Rajya Sabha majority. (iii) Presidents pushed back: K.R. Narayanan returned the Uttar Pradesh (1997) and Bihar (1998) recommendations. (iv) Media scrutiny and the electoral cost of appearing anti-federal rose.

Not abolished, but disciplined. It is still used where machinery genuinely fails — Jammu and Kashmir (2018–19) and Manipur (2025).

Judicial review turned Article 356 from a political weapon into a constitutional emergency brake; codifying Bommai's safeguards would complete that shift.

224 words · spine used: D (opening) → B/H → Gains/Gaps → Reforms → Judgement

A3 · 2023 GS-II Q3 · 10 marks · 150 words

"The states in India seem reluctant to empower urban local bodies both functionally as well as financially." Comment.

The 74th Amendment (1992) listed 18 functions for municipalities in the Twelfth Schedule, but left actual devolution to state law (Art. 243W uses 'may'). The statement largely holds.

Functionally: parastatals such as development authorities and water boards keep planning and utilities; Metropolitan Planning Committees are rarely working; mayors are mostly indirectly elected with short terms, while state-appointed commissioners hold executive power.

Financially: own revenue, mainly property tax, is weak; GST subsumed octroi and entry tax; State Finance Commissions are delayed and their advice ignored; borrowing and municipal bonds are limited to a few cities.

Why: rivalry between legislators and councillors, capacity gaps and the permissive text.

Way forward: statutory activity mapping, property-tax reform tied to Finance Commission grants, empowered Metropolitan Planning Committees and directly elected mayors with fixed tenure.

Cities will be governed well only when councils, not parastatals, own their functions and funds.

144 words · spine used: D (opening) → B/H → Gains/Gaps → Reforms → Judgement

6 Reform bank

Every reform line names the mechanism, the institution responsible and the accountability consequence.

Memorise word for word

Theme	Mechanism	Institution	Accountability consequence
T1	Statutory activity mapping that assigns each Eleventh/Twelfth Schedule subject to a tier with matching funds and staff	State legislature, with MoPR's devolution index as the benchmark	The SFC and the CAG report devolution gaps to the assembly each year
T1	Grants conditional on audited accounts and a property-tax floor	Finance Commission and state governments	Unaudited bodies lose grants, so councils must publish accounts
T1	Directly elected mayors with a fixed five-year term and control over city agencies	State municipal law	Mayors answer to voters and councils, not to state-appointed commissioners
T2	Bring cesses and surcharges beyond a cap into the divisible pool	Parliament, by amending Arts. 270–271, with the Finance Commission monitoring	The FC reports the cap's breach to Parliament, which must justify it
T2	A standing Inter-State Council with its own secretariat and fixed meeting cycle	President's order under Art. 263, as Punchhi recommended	An annual report on Centre–state disputes laid before Parliament
T2	Appoint Governors after consulting the Chief Minister, with fixed tenure	Constitutional amendment of Arts. 155–156 (Sarkaria, Punchhi)	Removal only for stated cause, reviewable by courts
T3	Amend Art. 200 to set a time limit for decisions on Bills	Parliament, by constitutional amendment (Punchhi suggested six months for reserved Bills)	Delay beyond the limit becomes a reviewable breach of a constitutional duty
T3	A binding code of conduct for Governors on discretion and appointments	Inter-State Council adopts it; President issues it	Departures must be recorded with reasons, which the Assembly can debate
T3	Speaker to decide disqualification petitions within three months	Tenth Schedule amendment, codifying Padi Kaushik Reddy (2025)	Missed deadlines open the decision to judicial review
T4	Finalise the Memorandum of Procedure with timelines and a secretariat	Supreme Court collegium with the Union Law Ministry	Reasons and timelines are published, so delays can be traced
T4	Amend the Judges (Inquiry) Act so inquiries continue after resignation and findings carry consequences	Parliament	Resignation can no longer erase the record of misconduct
T4	A cooling-off period before post-retirement appointments	Parliament by law, or a full-court resolution	Removes the incentive to please the executive before retirement
T5	Rules for screening PILs, with costs for frivolous petitions	Supreme Court rules under Art. 145	Admission becomes reasoned and reviewable
T5	Dialogic remedies: courts set principles and timelines, legislatures enact	Parliament and state legislatures, as after Vishaka (POSH Act 2013)	Compliance hearings track whether the legislature acted
T5	A permanent constitutional division of the Supreme Court	Parliament and the SC (Law Commission 229th Report, 2009)	Constitutional questions decided on time, by benches of known strength
T6	A minimum number of sitting days (NCRWC suggested 120 for the Lok Sabha, 100 for the Rajya Sabha)	Parliament, by law or its Rules	Shortfalls are reported to the House and the public each year
T6	Default referral of bills to committees unless the Speaker records reasons	Rules of Procedure of each House	Bypassing scrutiny requires a recorded, public justification
T6	Limit whips to confidence and Money Bills	Tenth Schedule amendment (Law Commission 170th Report, 1999; Dinesh Goswami 1990)	MPs vote on other bills by conscience and answer to their voters
T7	Disqualification petitions decided by an independent tribunal, or by the President or Governor on the ECI's binding advice	Constitutional amendment of the Tenth Schedule (Dinesh Goswami 1990; Meghachandra 2020; Padi Kaushik Reddy 2025)	Decisions become time-bound, reasoned and free of party interest
T7	A CEC selection panel that includes the CJI	Parliament, amending the 2023 Act (Tarkunde 1975; Law Commission 255th Report 2015)	Appointments gain bipartisan legitimacy

Theme	Mechanism	Institution	Accountability consequence
T7	Disqualification on framing of charges for serious offences, with safeguards	Parliament, amending the RPA (Law Commission 244th Report 2014)	Parties face a legal cost for fielding such candidates
T8	A National Tribunals Commission to run appointments, service conditions and administration	Parliament (SC direction of Nov 2025; a 2026 Bill passed the Lok Sabha in August 2026)	Tribunals report to an independent body, reviewable by courts, not to the parent ministry
T8	Tenure and age rules fixed in line with the Madras Bar judgments	Parliament	Members cannot be pressured through reappointment
T8	Appeals to High Court division benches rather than straight to the SC	Parliament, amending parent statutes	Restores the High Courts' supervisory role (L. Chandra Kumar)
T9	Findings of NHRC, NCSC and NCST binding unless rejected with written reasons	Parliament, amending the PHRA and adding to Arts. 338–338A	Governments must justify non-compliance before the legislature
T9	Commissioners' tenure and pay fixed in the statute	Parliament, amending the RTI Act	The executive can no longer vary terms to signal displeasure
T9	A permanent Finance Commission secretariat	Parliament, amending the FC Act 1951	Continuity and data between commissions, reported to Parliament
T10	Rights-impact assessment for new bills	Parliament, through its Rules and committees	Bills that dilute recognised rights must say so openly
T10	Independent oversight of the Data Protection Board	Parliament, amending the DPDP Act	Privacy is protected from the state as well as from companies
T11	Pre-legislative consultation and committee scrutiny for every amendment bill	Parliament, through its Rules (and the 2014 pre-legislative consultation policy)	Major changes are debated before votes are counted
T13	A lobbying disclosure register	Parliament, by law	Who met whom on what becomes public
T13	Internal party democracy and accounts audited and published	ECI, under amended RPA s. 29A	Parties lose recognition benefits if they do not comply

7 Judgment bank

Memorise word for word

Case	Year	Holding	Use in
Berubari	1960	Preamble not part; cession needs Art. 368	T11
Golaknath	1967	FR unamendable; prospective overruling	T11
Kesavananda Bharati	1973	Basic structure	T11
Shamsher Singh	1974	Governor and President act on advice	T3
Raj Narain	1975	Free and fair elections, separation of powers basic	T7, T11
Maneka Gandhi	1978	Fair, just, reasonable procedure	T10
Minerva Mills	1980	Limited amending power; FR–DPSP balance	T11
S.P. Gupta	1981	PIL standing; First Judges	T4, T5
Jyoti Basu	1982	Right to vote is statutory	T7
Olga Tellis	1985	Right to livelihood	T10
Kihoto Hollohan	1992	Speaker's defection decisions reviewable	T7
SCAORA	1993	Collegium	T4
S.R. Bommai	1994	Art. 356 reviewable; floor test; federalism basic	T2
Lal Babu Hussein	1995	Due process before deleting voters on citizenship doubts	T7
L. Chandra Kumar	1997	Tribunals under HC review	T8
Vineet Narain	1997	CVC statutory; CBI insulated	T9
Vishaka	1997	Workplace harassment guidelines	T5, T10

Case	Year	Holding	Use in
Prakash Singh	2006	Police reform directions	T5
Rameshwar Prasad	2006	Mala fide dissolution of Bihar Assembly	T3
I.R. Coelho	2007	Ninth Schedule under basic structure	T11
B.P. Singhal	2010	Governor's removal not arbitrary	T3
Lily Thomas	2013	Immediate disqualification on conviction	T7
NALSA	2014	Gender self-identification	T10
Manoj Narula	2014	Constitutional morality	T4
SCAORA (NJAC)	2015	NJAC struck down	T4
Nabam Rebia	2016	Governor's discretion limited	T3
Puttaswamy	2017	Privacy	T10
GNCTD v Union	2018	LG bound by aid and advice	T2
Common Cause	2018	Living wills	T5, T10
Rojer Mathew	2019	Money Bill certification referred; tribunal rules	T6, T8
Meghachandra	2020	Speakers: three months; independent tribunal suggested	T7
Jaishri Patil	2021	Maratha quota; led to 105th Amendment	T9
Mohit Minerals	2022	GST Council advice persuasive	T2
Anoop Baranwal	2023	Interim CEC panel with CJI	T7
In re Art. 370	2023	Abrogation upheld	T2
ADR (electoral bonds)	2024	Scheme struck down	T7, T13
Sita Soren	2024	No privilege for bribes	T6
Ranjitsinh	2024	Climate change and Arts. 14, 21	T10
Padi Kaushik Reddy	2025	Three-month deadline for Telangana Speaker	T3, T7
Presidential Reference	2025	No court-set timelines; no deemed assent	T3, T5
Madras Bar Association	2025	Tribunal Reforms Act provisions struck; NTC ordered	T8

8 Selective Article spine for Mains

High-ROI Articles only — the ones that open or anchor Mains answers. Not an index.

Art.	Use
1	Union of States — the federal identity line
13, 32, 226	Judicial review base
14, 15(3), 16	Equality and gender justice
19, 21	Speech, movement, life — the rights engine
39(b), 40, 44, 50	DPSP pegs for local government, UCC, judicial separation
74, 75(3), 78	Advice, collective responsibility, PM's duty
105, 108, 110	Privileges, joint sitting, Money Bill
123, 213	Ordinances (Krishna Kumar Singh)
124, 217, 121/211	Judges: appointment, removal, no discussion of conduct
142	Complete justice (and its limits, 2025)
148–151	CAG and audit reports

Art.	Use
239AA	Delhi
243G, 243W, 243I, 243K	Devolution, SFC, SEC
249–254	Legislative overrides
262–263	Water disputes; Inter-State Council
270–271, 275, 280, 279A	Fiscal federalism
312	All-India Services
323A, 323B	Tribunals
324, 326, 329	ECI, adult suffrage, election disputes
338–338B	NCSC, NCST, NCBC
352, 356, 360	Emergencies
368	Amending power

Art.	Use
153, 155–156, 163	Governor: appointment, pleasure, discretion
200–201	Assent and reservation

Art.	Use
Tenth Schedule	Anti-defection

9 Mains analytical question bank

Eight recent PYQs and sixteen predicted questions built from the audit's patterns and the 2024–26 developments. Each carries its theme and a one-line approach. Understand and reproduce flexibly

#	Source	Marks	Theme	Question	Approach
1	2026	10	T7	Is the right to vote a fundamental right? Discuss the ECI's position in revising electoral rolls. Can it examine citizenship?	Statutory right (Jyoti Basu, Kuldip Nayar) with Art. 326 base and 19(1)(a) expression (PUCL) → Art. 324 superintendence + RPA 1950 → citizenship is for the Union under the Citizenship Act; ECI can verify eligibility with due process (Lal Babu Hussein) → safeguards.
2	2026	10	T7	Has the Speaker's office become vulnerable to partisan politics under the anti-defection regime? Suggest institutional changes.	Kihoto → delays (Telangana 2025, Meghachandra) → reforms: tribunal or ECI-advised decision, 3-month rule, UK convention.
3	2026	15	T3	Position of the Governor; nature of assent power; is he bound by aid and advice in all functions?	Art. 153/163 → Shamsher Singh → Art. 200 options and the 2025 opinion → discretion areas → reforms (timelines, code).
4	2026	15	T2	How far has Indian federalism accommodated diversity? Role of asymmetric federalism; dispute-resolution reforms.	Reorganisation, Sixth Schedule, 371 → Art. 370 (2023) → water and border disputes, ISC → reforms.
5	2025	15	T11	Procedural and substantive limits on Parliament's amending power.	368 procedure → 24th, Kesavananda → Minerva, Coelho, NJAC → 131st Bill's failure as procedural check.
6	2025	15	T4, T12	Evolution of the collegium; compare appointment of SC judges in India and the USA.	Three Judges cases → NJAC → MoP → US nomination and Senate confirmation → merits of each.
7	2025	10	T8	Need for administrative tribunals; impact of the 2021 rationalisation.	323A/B → 2021 Act abolished appellate tribunals → Nov 2025 judgment and NTC → assessment.
8	2024	10	T1	Role of local bodies in good governance; pros and cons of merging rural and urban bodies.	3Fs → urbanisation and peri-urban gaps → merger pros (planning) and cons (identity, scale) → reforms.
9	Predicted	15	T4	'Resignation should not become an escape from accountability.' Examine the process for removing judges in the light of recent events.	Art. 124(4), 217, Judges Inquiry Act → Ramaswami, Sen, Varma (2025–26) → reforms to the Act.
10	Predicted	15	T3	'The Governor is a constitutional head, not a parallel government.' Discuss with reference to the 2025 advisory opinion.	Art. 200–201 → TN ruling (Apr 2025) → reference opinion (Nov 2025) → Punchhi timelines.
11	Predicted	10	T8	Can tribunals be independent without a National Tribunals Commission?	Madras Bar series → 2025 judgment → 2026 Bill → design of the NTC.
12	Predicted	15	T2	Delimitation after the freeze: reconcile representation by population with federal fairness.	Arts. 81–82, 84th and 87th → 2026 freeze end → North–South concern → weighted options; 131st Bill's failure.
13	Predicted	10	T6	What does the falling referral of bills to committees mean for the quality of law-making?	PRS figures by Lok Sabha → examples → default-referral reform.
14	Predicted	10	T9	Should the CBI have its own statute? Examine in the light of consent withdrawals.	DSPE s. 6 → consent withdrawals → court-ordered probes → statute design.
15	Predicted	10	T9	Has the RTI regime been weakened since 2019? Examine transparency versus privacy.	2019 amendment → DPDP Act s. 44(3) (Nov 2025) → Puttaswamy proportionality → reform.

#	Source	Marks	Theme	Question	Approach
16	Predicted	15	T7	Has the anti-defection law achieved its purpose? Suggest reforms.	52nd, 91st → resignation route, delays → Kihoto, Meghachandra, Telangana 2025 → reforms.
17	Predicted	10	T1, T7	What must happen before the 106th Amendment's women's reservation operates?	Census and delimitation trigger → 15-year sunset, rotation → the 131st Bill's failure (Apr 2026).
18	Predicted	15	T7, T2	Simultaneous elections: constitutional changes required and federal concerns.	Kovind Committee 2024 → 129th Bill with JPC → Arts. 83, 172, 356 → federal and accountability concerns (Mains 2017).
19	Predicted	10	T10	Sub-classification within Scheduled Castes: equality of opportunity or fragmentation?	Chinnaiah 2004 → Davinder Singh 2024 → creamy layer debate → data needs.
20	Predicted	15	T2	Cesses and surcharges have eroded fiscal federalism. Examine.	Arts. 270–271 → share outside divisible pool → FC response → cap reform.
21	Predicted	10	T9	Do human rights commissions need binding powers?	PHRA limits → NHRC record → binding-unless-reasoned reform.
22	Predicted	10	T13	Should India regulate lobbying?	No law → corporate–political convergence (2026 PYQ) → disclosure register.
23	Predicted	15	T12	Compare judicial appointment systems of India, the UK and the USA.	Collegium vs JAC (2005) vs Senate confirmation → independence and accountability trade-offs.
24	Predicted	10	T6	Is the Money Bill route undermining bicameralism?	Art. 110(3) → Aadhaar 2018, Rojer Mathew 2019 referral → Rajya Sabha's role.

10 Closed-book drill and scoring rubric

Closed-book drill

Understand and reproduce flexibly

1. Recite the D-W-B-H-G-G-R-J spine with one functional phrase each.
2. Decode five verbs: Discuss, Examine, Critically examine, Comment, To what extent.
3. For T1, T2, T3, T7, T9, T10, T12: give the definition line, two gains, two gaps and one full reform line — three minutes per theme.
4. Give eight cases with year and holding from the judgment bank, one per theme.
5. Draw the Art. 200 flowchart and the India–USA–UK–France comparison grid from memory.
6. State three 2025–26 developments that change a Mains answer: the assent opinion, the tribunal judgment, the Varma inquiry.

Scoring rubric (out of 10)

Criterion	Marks	What earns it
Structure	2	Spine visible; headings or clear paragraphs
Demand coverage	2	Every part of the question answered, in the verb's shape
Evidence	2	At least one Article, one case with year, one data point or report
Reform specificity	2	Mechanism + institution + accountability
Judgement and balance	1	A clear verdict that weighs both sides
Presentation and limit	1	Within words and time; a diagram where it helps

Sources

Constitution of India · M. Laxmikanth, *Indian Polity* · Sarkaria (1988) and Punchhi (2010) Commission reports · NCRWC (2002) · 2nd ARC reports · Law Commission Reports 170, 229, 244, 255 · Dinesh Goswami Committee (1990) · PRS Legislative Research data on sittings and committee referrals · ADR analysis of the 2024 Lok Sabha · LiveLaw and SCC Online reports on the Presidential Reference opinion (20 Nov 2025), Madras Bar Association (19 Nov 2025), the Justice Varma inquiry (2025–26) and Padi Kaushik Reddy (2025) · reports on the JPC on the Constitution (129th Amendment) Bill · UnlockIAS GS-II PYQs 2013–2026 (theme counts are my re-sort).